Speak

By Laurie Halse Anderson

MELINDA: I am Outcast. I don't do parties. No thanks. I trot out excuses: homework, strict parents, tuba practice, late-night dentist appointment, have to feed the warthogs. I don't have a good track record with parties. I am not going to think about it. It was ugly, but it's over, and I'm not going to think about it.

INTRODUCTION

At the end of the summer before she enters high school, Melinda attends a party at which two bad things happen to her. She gets drunk, and she is raped. Shocked and scared, she calls the police, who break up the party and sends everyone home. She tells no one of her rape, and the other students, even her best friends, turn against her for ruining their good time. By the time school starts, she is completely alone, and utterly desolate. She withdraws more and more into herself, rarely talking, cutting classes, ignoring assignments, and becoming more estranged daily from the world around her. Few people penetrate her shell; one of them is Mr. Freeman, her art teacher, who works with her to help her express what she has so deeply repressed. When the unthinkable happens--the same upperclassman who raped her at the party

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attacks her again--something within the new Melinda says no, and in repelling her attacker, she becomes whole again.

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MELINDA: There is no point looking for my ex-friends. Our clan, the Plain Janes, has splintered and the pieces are being absorbed by rival factions.

Her eyes meet mine for a second. It's Rachel. "I hate you," she mouths silently. She turns her back to me and laughs with her friends. I bite my lip. My lip bleeds a little. It tastes like metal. I need to sit down.

The Homecoming pep rally, and Heather drags me into the freshman section of the bleachers. The girl behind me taps me on the shoulder with her long black nails. She had heard Heather introduce me. "Sordino?" She asks. "You're Melinda Sordino?"

I turn around. She blows a black bubble and sucks it back into her mouth. I nod. Heather waves to a sophomore she knows across the gym. The girl pokes

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me harder. “Aren’t you the one who called the cops at Kyle Rodger’s party at the end of the summer?”

A block of ice freezes our section of the bleachers. Heads snap in my direction with the sound of a hundred paparazzi cameras. Another girl chimes in. “My brother got arrested at that party. He got fired because of the arrest. I can’t believe you did that. Asshole.”

I have worked so hard to forget every second of that stupid party, and here I am in the middle of a hostile crowd that hates me for what I had to do. I can’t tell what really happened. I can’t even look at that part myself.

IT is my nightmare and I can’t wake up. I’m hanging a poster outside the metal-shop room when IT creeps up. Little flecks of metal slice through my veins. IT whispers to me.

I can smell him over the noise of the metal shop and I drop my poster and the masking tape and I want to

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throw up and I can smell him and I run and he remembers and he knows. He whispers in my ear.

“Freshmeat.” That’s what IT whispers.

IT found me again. I thought I could ignore IT. There are four hundred other freshmen in here, two hundred female. Plus all the other grades. But he whispers to me. Andy Evans. He’s a creep. He’s a bastard. Stay away!!!!! He should be locked up. He thinks he’s all that. Call the cops

Rachel got us to the end-of-summer party, a cheerleader party, with beer and seniors and music. She blackmailed her brother, Jimmy to drive us. We were all sleeping over at Rachel’s house. Her mother thought Jimmy was taking us roller-skating.

Most people hung at the edge of the lights. They looked like models. I felt like such a little kid. Rachel found a way to fit in. I tasted a beer. It was worse than cough medicine. I gulped it down. Another beer and

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one more, then I worried I would throw up. I walked out of the crowd, toward the woods.

A step behind me. A senior. And then he was talking to me, flirting with me. This gorgeous cover-model guy. His hair was way better than mine, his every inch a tanned muscle, and he had straight white teeth.

Flirting with me! Where was Rachel - - she had to see this! He took my hand and pulled me close to him. I breathed in cologne and beer and something I couldn't identify. I fit in against his body perfectly, my head level with his shoulder.

He wrapped one arm around my back. His other hand slid down to my butt. I thought that was a little rude, but my tongue was thick with beer and I couldn't figure out how to tell him to slow down. This is what high school was supposed to feel like. Where was Rachel? She had to see this!

He tilted my face up to his. He kissed me, man kiss, hard sweet and deep. Nearly knocked me off my feet,

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that kiss. And I thought for a minute there that I had a boyfriend, I would start high school with a boyfriend, older and stronger and ready to watch out for me. He kissed me again. His teeth ground hard against my lips. It was hard to breathe.

"Do you want to?" He asked

What did he say? I didn't answer. I didn't know. I didn't speak.

We were on the ground. When did that happen? "No". No I did not like this. I was on the ground and he was on top of me. My lips mumble something about leaving, about a friend who needs me. I can hear myself - - I'm mumbling like a deranged drunk. He is so heavy. There is a boulder on me.

I open my mouth to breathe, to scream, and his hand covers it. In my head, my voice is as clear as a bell: "NO I DON"T WANT TO!" But I can't spit it out.

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I'm trying to remember how we got on the ground and where the moon went and wham! Shirt up, shorts down, and the ground smells wet and dark and NO! - I'm not really here, I'm definitely back at Rachel's, crimping my hair and gluing on fake nails, and he smells like beer and mean and he hurts me hurts me hurts me and gets up....and zips his jeans....and smiles.

The next thing I saw was the telephone. I stood in the middle of a drunken crowd and I called 911 because I needed help. All those visits from Officer Friendly in second grade paid off. A lady answered the phone, "Police, state your emergency," and I saw my face in the window over the kitchen sink and no words came out of my mouth. Who was that girl? I had never seen her before. Tears oozed down my face, over my bruised lips, pooling on the handset. "It's OK," said the nice lady on the phone. "We have your location. Officers are on the way. Are you hurt? Are you being threatened?" Someone grabbed the phone from my hands and listened. A scream - - the cops were

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coming! Blue and cherry lights flashing in the kitchen-sink window. Rachel's face - - so angry - - in mine. Someone slapped me. I crawled out of the room through a forest of legs. Outside, the moon smiled goodbye and slipped away.

I walked home to an empty house. Without a word.

IT happened. There is no avoiding it, no forgetting. No running away, or flying, or burying, or hiding. Andy Evans raped me in August when I was drunk and too young to know what was happening. It wasn't my fault. He hurt me. It wasn't my fault. And I'm not going to let it kill me. I can grow.

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2022 National Qualifier - MS
NIETOC
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
NY State Qualifier
SD State Qualifier

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